

Darwin Smith

Product Designer who builds in code

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EDUCATION

University of California, San Diego

B.S. in Mathematics and Computer Science

San Diego, CA

June 2026

EXPERIENCE

Software Engineer & Product Designer

Nov 2025 – Present

Veraflux (veraflux.org), self-founded, pre-launch health-research product

San Diego, CA

- Designed and built Veraflux, a pre-launch product that turns PubMed studies into cited supplement reports personalized to age, sex, and goal. Set the brief and criteria, chose from rendered options, and measured the results.
- Color & accessibility:** rebuilt an evidence badge that used the safety red and failed WCAG AA (2.66–3.68:1) as a single-hue scale (4.69–4.77:1). Directed a 22-selector contrast audit and fixed 209 light-mode failures.
- Typography:** caught fused letters a spot check missed with a 676-pair sweep, then rendered 12 typefaces on live pages before replacing Inter and ranked 60 fonts by letter-pair evenness for display type.
- Legibility over motion:** single-frame checks kept passing text over the animated hero, so measured contrast on inked pixels across a 90-second cycle at six widths: worst case 2.47:1 on mobile, fixed by reshaping the backdrop.
- AI-generated reports:** settled a statistic style in three iterations, previewed collapsed sections in a sentence, and clarified safety labels. Kept citations per paragraph, because sentence guesses can credit the wrong study.
- Label scan:** designed the photo-to-results flow for one-to-five-minute waits. The payroll comes before the photo, one ingredient list carries through every step, and the wait shows elapsed time, never fake progress.
- UX writing:** rewrote error copy after an outage exposed exception text. Tone follows whether a problem is recoverable, retry appears only where it works. Added delete safeguards; the only confirmation guarded a harmless action.
- Spacing system:** unified 8 left edges (9–45px) across the 12 states of the signed-in search card into one 16px gutter, and made the barely visible card stand out by darkening the page behind it (1.045 to 1.151:1).
- Keyboard access:** blocked focus inside collapsed report sections and glossary groups, where about 160 invisible links were still tabbable. Moved signup validation to submit, so keyboard users reach the error message.
- Designed a home page section that opens an invented, FDA-shaped label into real PubMed study counts per ingredient, with no score or ranking. Rows keep label order, since a sorted list would read as a verdict.
- Content strategy:** reviewed the argument each home page section makes and found none explained how studies are chosen, the product's differentiator. Rebuilt the trust section around it and moved a real report above the fold.
- Design system:** type, spacing, radius, color, motion, border, stacking, and icon-source rules became 13 CI checks whose exemption lists fail once an entry is unused. Moved 212 font-size declarations to tokens, no pixel change.
- Engineering:** built the Node/Express API and a Python/FastAPI pipeline with 13 LLM stages across Gemini and Claude. The server drops any citation outside the studies the model was given; an ingredient brief costs \$0.018.

Test Engineer

Nov 2023 – Apr 2026

SiteHive

San Diego, CA

- Ran US QA and final validation for IoT deployments as technical contact for major enterprise clients.
- Diagnosed firmware and network faults before deployment and tightened validation for recurring defects.

PROJECTS

darwinls.github.io, portfolio and design system | *CSS, SVG, Python, Playwright*

Dec 2025 – Present

- Designed a landscape identity and the four-material glass system on it, which degrades through four capability tiers from edge refraction to opaque. 205 tokens, color written once with `light-dark()`, one light source.
- Documented it and added 9 CI guards that fail on an off-scale radius, a raw color, or a new breakpoint. A Playwright pass measures contrast against the pixels behind each text node; 7 pages hold zero failures.

SKILLS

Design: User flows, interaction design, information architecture, visual and typographic design, design systems, content design and UX writing, responsive design, prototyping in code

Accessibility: WCAG 2.2 (color contrast, target size, focus order), contrast and color audits (OKLab/OKLCH)

Prototyping & tools: React, TypeScript, HTML/CSS, Framer Motion, Git, Claude Code (AI-assisted prototyping)

Engineering: Node/Express, Python/FastAPI, PostgreSQL, Stripe, Docker, LLM APIs (Gemini, Claude)